



PAPAYA POWERPLAY

It's become clear that in the current landscape, there's **no one else** capable of consistently challenging McLaren.

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Eleven races into the Formula One season, the spotlight has firmly been on McLaren throughout. And for yet another weekend, it was a tight, riveting contest between the thriving drivers of the defending constructors' champion. Lando Norris and Oscar Piastri have been the centres of attention, and rightfully so, with the two McLaren drivers having only each other standing in the way more often than not.

At the Austrian Grand Prix, it was the bright papaya cars — a similar shade to the orange hue that usually swallows this track when a certain Max Verstappen shines — that stole the show at the Red Bull Ring. But it was Norris' turn to be the leading car, keeping Piastri behind by bare margins to take his seventh career victory and third this season.

The Red Bull Ring, a small track with blistering lap times, has always been a fun contest for the drivers. With backmarkers, however, often impeding the way, it adds an obstacle element to the event — a frustrating one at that. Piastri would agree, considering his attempt to catch the back of the Briton was often strained by the lower-down drivers.

Norris was sure to leave behind his miserly pole-to-win conversion after an authoritative performance in qualifying. But he knew it wouldn't be long before his friendly foe was right on his tail. Piastri only had Charles Leclerc standing in his way — the Ferrari driver, despite his vow to trouble the McLarens, fell well short of his far-fetched claim.

The two soon began their tussle for the top spot, but the opening lap is never without its theatrics and collisions. Crowd favourite Verstappen, who had triumphed here a record five times, could only manage a seventh-place start. To make matters worse, his outing ended early when Mercedes rookie Kimi Antonelli lost control and crashed into the Red Bull driver.

Both were forced to retire, prompting a brief Safety Car intervention that cleared the way for a straight fight between the McLaren teammates. When racing resumed, all